

Our interview with **Mario Einaudi**, Head of Digital Collections and Imaging Services at The Huntington Library, Art Museum, and Botanical Gardens.

Per the policy of The Huntington, the interview was not allowed to be recorded.

Job Overview

- **What is your role, and what do you do? How does your position support the Huntington as an institution and its mission?**
 - [Mission](#) [The Huntington]: Education and make available materials to the greater public
 - Managerial head of Digital Collections and Imaging Services
 - Coordinate the management of materials across the institution, including with other departments for the proper handling and organization of materials
 - Coordinate the principle photographer and digitization manager
 - [Role of the Imaging Services Department](#):
 - Make materials available to the public via [The Huntington Digital Library](#)
 - Do imaging and metadata for exhibitions and catalog
 - [Managerial philosophy](#):
 - Protect staff from unwanted intrusions from the director or other senior staff. Ergo, questions go through Mario first.
 - Need to know what people under him are doing and be able to do their parts in case people are out sick or other staff need help
 - Wearing multiple
 - Push for changes when able to
 - *Example*: was able to get funding to hire one member for the department
- **How did you end up in your role? Did anything draw you to digital collections or digital library work?**
 - Overseeing libraries since 2009
 - Been at the Huntington for 28 years
 - In the mid-2000s, was picked to start The Huntington Digital Library due to his familiarity with databases and metadata and formal background in libraries and archives 2
 - In 2022, during COVID, was chosen to lead the new Digital Collections department after his director decided The Huntington needed one
 - Once working in digitization, liked the work and the project management side—coordinating photographers, meeting standards, meeting requirements for grants.

Tasks and Technical Skills

- **Generally, what duties does someone in digital collections/libraries perform? How do the duties of the role change at different levels of seniority?**
 - The department rarely takes entry level workers because need to hire people with more advanced skill sets and professional experience due to how the imaging department works
 - *Example:* Have one entry-level metadata person, and she was hired due to her cataloging background
 - *Example:* The internal imaging coordinator is trained librarian but oversees all imaging queries. Needs to describe materials as they come in or manipulate metadata records for internal use before implementing the records into the DAM system
- **What qualities does someone need to possess to get selected for leadership roles?**
 - Need to have a sense of gregariousness and sense of the institution's direction in order to direct the behaviour of the department or staff in the direction of the institution's mission
 - *Example:* Picked the person for the Head of Photographers because he showed skills for leading people that other people did not have. He had a sense of gregariousness and the attitude of "How can I do my work while fitting it within the mission of the institution?"
 - Being willing to color outside the lines and take risks, especially at The Huntington, where you can go out of the norms and push the culture in a better direction.
 - Being willing to listen to those who are below you and to help them grow and develop into their own leaders and professional they aspire to be.
 - Take a group of people and take them where they need to go. Also, take people where they don't want to go and may be uncomfortable.
 - *Example:* The department had an open house, and he took 20-40 people to the event. Photographers and metadata specialists like each other but are introverts by nature. By attending, the workers got validation for the work that they do.
 - *Rationale:* Working in the digital realms at The Huntington, the department is behind the scenes. Therefore, people don't know what the department does. Images appear fantastic, but people don't think about the skill set, equipment, or metadata needed to do [the imaging].

Training

- **If a student was interested in digital collections or library services, what kinds of classes should they take? What kinds of internships should they be looking for? Are there any specific technical skills students should target?**
 - Skills:

- Metadata and cataloging
 - Cataloging teaches rules to make an object findable, AKA metadata
 - Know how to do library and archival cataloging because they're very different
 - Need to know the basics before getting to break the rules
- Information engineering
 - Know how to build information into a cohesive structure that can be used to find an object within a system
- Learn database systems, digital asset management (DAM), and content management systems
 - Typically learn these on the job
 - *Example:* The Imaging Department has a metadata specialist who works in CMS. She's learning the new system on the side—how to move materials in that system for bringing in images.
- Internships are important yet hard to come by. Working or helping on small projects is beneficial.
 - The Huntington doesn't do internships (Imaging specifically), but they are expanding. Currently, they don't have space or time.
- Imaging:
 - Learn how to use a scanner
 - Lots of institutions hire students for copy imaging (using a scanner, like a flatbed or a bookeye, which are controlled by a machine and the machine does the scanning)
 - The Huntington uses cameras, so a trained photographer skillset is necessary. Someone would need to know how to set profiles for each camera, focal points, color targets, set a timelines, and set targets to meet FADGI (Federal Agencies Digital Guidelines Initiative).
- Get yourself started, but be open to grow in whatever position you are in. Value will be there in the future.
- **Was there any additional training that you needed to undertake once you started your position at the Huntington? Have you undergone any specific training since starting your career you found really beneficial?**
 - Trained specifically as archivist and librarian, so needed more training in digital projects
 - Around 2014, he did additional training through the Northeast Document Conservation Center ([NEDCC](#)) in their weeklong [Digital Directions](#) program, a training for digitization projects and managers, which helped him gain the skills in that field.

- At a certain point you can't keep learning; it becomes difficult.
 - *Example:* Mario knows about APIs but asks how to use them on a regular basis or asks a younger staff member to run it for him.

Professional Development

- **What kinds of professional development opportunities exist for your specialization—associations, conferences, journals, job boards, et cetera?**
 - Professional development generally exists as on the job training, outside courses, the Internet, and networking (word-of-mouth)
 - At the time, The Huntington didn't do a lot of professional development, so would have to pay for outside training out of pocket, which was not super feasible on a library salary.
 - Organizations:
 - **Digital Library Federation (DLF)**: conferences, trainings, community
 - **International Image Interoperability Framework (IIIF)**: a series of APIs that can pull from digital libraries and make it available to a larger group of people.
 - Triple IF wanted Huntington to be part of it, but they didn't have funding. However, The Huntington supported it tangentially and forced OCLC to include Triple IF.
 - IIIF has fantastic programs, great way to learn things.
 - **Northeast Document Conservation Center (NEDCC)**
 - The Huntington also uses ALA and SAA job boards

Job Market

- **Is the field growing or shrinking? Which parts do you see growing and shrinking?**
 - The field is static—neither growing or shrinking.
 - When he entered the field, people said it would be a great field to enter because people would retire. People didn't retire and couldn't afford to, especially with incidents like the 2008 financial crisis.
 - *Example:* The Huntington has only added 4 people in about 10 years.

Trends

- **Are there any particular trends in the field (e.g., unpaid internships, temporary contracts), and how do professionals in the field react? What do you think would need to change to address these issues?**
 - Unpaid internships and contracts are not a good trend
 - Institutional memory is important because long-term employees can learn the collections much better, especially in a place like The Huntington that has over 12 million items.

- Forcing people to leave can cause bad blood and create a reputation that the institution doesn't care for its employees. Leaving can also feel defeating
 - Funding is a problem
 - The Huntington doesn't necessarily use money wisely, and there is a lack of understanding of how things work and how much things actually cost.
 - *Example:* had the open house because they have expensive equipment and most people don't know how much they cost (e.g., \$50-100k cameras). People question why they can't just use a phone camera or why they need expensive equipment. High quality cameras capture the object as it is whereas smartphone cameras automatically alter the image after its taken
 - *Example:* explained to a programmer what a catalog record was, and the programmer was impressed by the organization of the data in the catalog record.
 - Need labor
 - Don't be afraid to hop around if it means a career advancement or better salary.
- **What kinds of institutional or political constraints exist in your line of work?**
 - Political: *gestures at the state of the world* ideological constraints from all levels of government, especially the federal level.
 - People, such as students, need to understand that there are political constraints against you that will prevent you from doing what you want to do.
 - Need to have the mentality, "Go ahead and do something, ask for forgiveness later."
 - You, the worker, know what the truth is.
 - *Example:* Farmers hung pictures of frames of Mussolini to show how great he is. What the state police didn't see was that the farmers spit and slapped the portrait as they entered the house.
 - Institutional:
 - The Huntington is tight fisted with their money, acting like it's still 1940, and have been that way since the beginning (the phrase: "my way, their way, and the Huntington way")
 - There's turnover in institutions all the time, yet there's a belief system that somehow persists. And persists despite this change of people in the decades.
 - Understand where the politics are externally and internally

- Sometimes there are institutional reasons that prevent you from doing something, so you need to “color outside the lines.”
- The Huntington has undergone dramatic changes, yet institutionally, it’s taken a long time to understand.
 - *Example:* In the 1900s, very few PCs tied into servers. Five years before he arrived at The Huntington, a committee was deciding if they should move from typewriters to computers. Online cataloging is now a huge change.
- The role of an information professional is serving information, yet many don’t understand what an imaging lab is and its importance, even though the lab has been around for over 100 years.
 - Librarians are bad at advocating for themselves
- Power structures and power fights
 - Different leadership styles can cause friction (top down style vs “permissive”), which can cause problems between departments.
 - Mario has a more relaxed leadership style, which occasionally has caused issues when his employees communicate with other departments.
- Other issues: copyright, estates, etc

AI

- **Is AI making an appearance in your role in any capacity? Moving forward, how do you think AI will affect your job/field?**
 - Imaging department does not use AI. AI distorts everything
 - Could imagine using AI for 3D objects for computing power
 - AI could replace catalogers but also can’t because need the human to check errors
 - Huge improvement with handwriting recognition. AI can transcribe handwritten documentation much faster than a human.
 - An AI system could not be used for rare book cataloging because one needs to be able to gently handle the objects to collect the metadata.
- **Generally, what are people’s reactions to AI in your field?**
 - Worries: AI system records user behaviours, so using AI would release information into AI world unintentionally
- **Does the Huntington have an AI policy?**
 - Huntington does not have an AI policy, yet technical services is asking departments how they use it or not. Will most likely have a policy by the end of the year.